Chapter 4 — AOP and Proxies

Many things an application must do are not part of any single business rule: logging, timing, transactions, caching, security checks, retries. Written by hand inside every service method, they drown the business logic, and one forgotten line becomes a bug. **Aspect-Oriented Programming (AOP)** lets you write such a concern once and declare *where* it applies. Spring implements AOP with **proxies** — stand-in objects that wrap your beans — and the same mechanism makes `@Transactional`, `@Cacheable`, `@Async`, `@PreAuthorize` and Framework 7's `@Retryable` work.

Understanding proxies is the most useful piece of "Spring internals" knowledge: it explains the most common Spring bug (an annotation that silently does nothing) and comes up in almost every Spring interview.

All code lives in `code/aop-proxies/` — Spring Boot 4.1.1 / Framework 7.0 on Java 25. Every claim marked "proved" is checked by a JUnit test; outputs are real `mvn -q verify` output (log lines trimmed as `...`).

> **Prerequisites.** Beans, the `ApplicationContext` and `BeanPostProcessor`: Chapter 2. The Proxy *design pattern* without Spring: LLD Proxy Pattern.

4.1 Cross-cutting concerns and the AOP vocabulary

The problem it solves

An `OrderService` with ten methods must log each call, time it and run it in a transaction. Without AOP every method looks like this:

```
public String placeOrder(String item, int qty) {
    log.info("placeOrder {} {}", item, qty);          // logging
    long start = System.nanoTime();                    // timing
    TransactionStatus tx = txManager.getTransaction(def);  // transaction
    try {
        String id = /* ... the 3 lines that actually matter ... */;
        txManager.commit(tx);
        return id;
    } catch (RuntimeException e) {
        txManager.rollback(tx);
        throw e;
    } finally {
        metrics.record("placeOrder", System.nanoTime() - start);
    }
}
```

Such code is a **cross-cutting concern**: a requirement that *cuts across* many classes instead of living in one. Two symptoms:

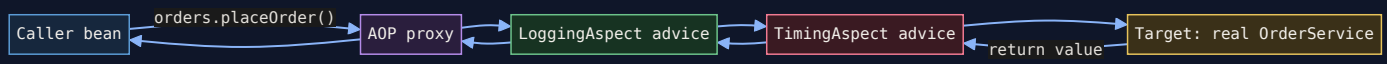
- **Scattering** — the same code spread over many classes.
- **Tangling** — each method mixes several unrelated concerns.

What it is

AOP modularises cross-cutting concerns: write the concern once in an **aspect**, describe with a **pointcut** which methods it applies to, and the framework applies it.

The vocabulary

Term	Meaning	In this chapter's code
Join point	A point during execution where behaviour *could* be added. In Spring AOP always **a method execution on a bean** (not field access, not constructors).	the call `orders.placeOrder("book", 2)`
Pointcut	A predicate selecting join points — *where*.	`execution(public * ch04.aop.OrderService.*(..))`
Advice	The code to run there, plus *when* (before, after, around...) — *what* and *when*.	`LoggingAspect.before(...)`
Aspect	A class bundling pointcuts and advice for one concern.	`LoggingAspect`, `TimingAspect`
Target object	The real object being advised.	the plain `OrderService` instance
AOP proxy	The object Spring creates that wraps the target and runs the advice. Other beans receive the proxy.	`OrderService$$SpringCGLIB$$0`
Weaving	Linking aspects with targets. Spring does it **at runtime by creating proxies**; AspectJ (the original, full AOP tool for Java) can do it at compile time or class-load time.	done by a `BeanPostProcessor` at startup
Advisor	Spring's internal pairing of one advice with one pointcut. Rarely written by hand.	—
Introduction	Adding a new interface to an advised object. Rarely used.	—



The caller *thinks* it holds an `OrderService`; it holds the proxy, which runs the advice chain and eventually calls the real object.

4.2 Writing aspects with `@Aspect`

How to set it up

1. Add the starter. In **Boot 4** it is `spring-boot-starter-aspectj` (called `spring-boot-starter-aop` up to Boot 3.x; renamed to make clear it brings AspectJ's annotation support):

```
<dependency>
  <groupId>org.springframework.boot</groupId>
  <artifactId>spring-boot-starter-aspectj</artifactId>
</dependency>
```

2. Boot's `AopAutoConfiguration` sees AspectJ on the classpath and switches on `@EnableAspectJAutoProxy` (property `spring.aop.auto`, default `true`). In plain Spring add `@EnableAspectJAutoProxy` to a `@Configuration` class yourself.
3. Annotate the class **both** `@Aspect` and `@Component` (or register it with `@Bean`). `@Aspect` alone is *not* a stereotype — scanning ignores it, and an aspect that is not a bean never runs.

The five kinds of advice

Annotation	Runs	Can it change the outcome?	Typical use
`@Before`	before the method	only by throwing (the method then never runs)	argument checks, audit "who called"
`@AfterReturning`	after a normal return	reads the return value (`returning=`), cannot replace it	log results, publish an event
`@AfterThrowing`	after the method throws	reads the exception (`throwing=`); it still propagates unless the advice throws a different one	translate/log errors
`@After`	always, like `finally`	no	release resources, clear context
`@Around`	wraps the call; *you* call `proceed()`	yes: skip the call, change arguments or return value, catch exceptions, retry	timing, caching, transactions, retries

Spring docs' rule: use the **least powerful** advice that does the job. A `@Before` cannot forget to call `proceed()` ; an `@Around` can.

Example: logging aspect

The business class knows nothing about logging (`OrderService.java`):

```java
@Service
public class OrderService {
    public String placeOrder(String item, int quantity) {
        return "order-" + item + "-x" + quantity;
    }
    public void cancel(String orderId) {
        if (orderId.startsWith("unknown")) {
            throw new IllegalArgumentException("no such order: " + orderId);
        }
    }
    @Timed("monthly-report")
    public String monthlyReport() throws InterruptedException {
        Thread.sleep(20);                  // pretend to do slow work
        return "report ready";
    }
}
```

The aspect (`LoggingAspect.java`) writes into a small `CallLog` bean so a test can check the exact order:

```java
@Aspect                 // "this class contains advice + pointcuts"
@Component              // ...and it must also be a bean, or Spring never sees it
@Order(1)               // lower number = outer layer = runs first on the way in
public class LoggingAspect {
    private final CallLog log;
    public LoggingAspect(CallLog log) { this.log = log; }

    // A named, reusable pointcut: every public method of OrderService
    @Pointcut("execution(public * ch04.aop.OrderService.*(..))")
    void orderServiceMethods() {}

    @Before("orderServiceMethods()")
    public void before(JoinPoint jp) {
        log.add("before " + jp.getSignature().getName() + " args=" + Arrays.toString(jp.getArgs()));
    }

    @AfterReturning(pointcut = "orderServiceMethods()", returning = "result")
    public void afterReturning(JoinPoint jp, Object result) {
        log.add("afterReturning " + jp.getSignature().getName() + " -> " + result);
    }

    @AfterThrowing(pointcut = "orderServiceMethods()", throwing = "ex")
    public void afterThrowing(JoinPoint jp, Exception ex) {
        log.add("afterThrowing " + jp.getSignature().getName() + " -> " + ex.getMessage());
    }

    @After("orderServiceMethods()")   // like 'finally': runs on success AND on exception
    public void after(JoinPoint jp) {
        log.add("after " + jp.getSignature().getName());
    }
}
```

- `@Pointcut` on an empty method gives the expression a reusable **name** (`orderServiceMethods()`); the body never runs.
- `JoinPoint` exposes the method signature, the arguments (`getArgs()`), the target (`getTarget()`) and the proxy (`getThis()`).
- `returning = "result"` binds the return value to the parameter named `result`; declaring it `String` instead of `Object` restricts matching to methods returning `String`.
- `throwing = "ex"` does the same for the exception; the parameter type also filters.

The test (AspectsTest.java):

```java
@Test
void adviceRunsAroundASuccessfulCall() {
    String result = orders.placeOrder("book", 2);
    System.out.println("result = " + result);
    log.lines().forEach(l -> System.out.println("  " + l));
    assertThat(log.lines()).containsExactly(
            "before placeOrder args=[book, 2]",
            "afterReturning placeOrder -> order-book-x2",
            "after placeOrder");
}

@Test
void adviceRunsWhenTheMethodThrows() {
    assertThatThrownBy(() -> orders.cancel("unknown-7"))
            .isInstanceOf(IllegalArgumentException.class);   // the aspect does not swallow it
    log.lines().forEach(l -> System.out.println("  " + l));
    assertThat(log.lines()).containsExactly(
            "before cancel args=[unknown-7]",
            "afterThrowing cancel -> no such order: unknown-7",
            "after cancel");
}
```

Output:

```
result = order-book-x2
  before placeOrder args=[book, 2]
  afterReturning placeOrder -> order-book-x2
  after placeOrder
  before cancel args=[unknown-7]
  afterThrowing cancel -> no such order: unknown-7
  after cancel
```

`@After` ran **after** `@AfterReturning` / `@AfterThrowing`. Since Framework 5.2.7, advice of the *same* aspect on the *same* join point has a fixed precedence — `@Around`, `@Before`, `@After`, `@AfterReturning`, `@AfterThrowing` from highest to lowest — and `@After` is effectively invoked after that aspect's returning/throwing advice, like a `finally` block.

`@Around` advice and custom annotations

`@Around` receives a `ProceedingJoinPoint`; `proceed()` continues to the next advice or the real method, and not calling it skips the method. A common pattern triggers an aspect with your own annotation:

```
@Retention(RetentionPolicy.RUNTIME)  // must be visible at runtime for the pointcut to see it
@Target(ElementType.METHOD)
public @interface Timed {
    String value() default "";       // optional label
}
```

`RUNTIME` retention is required because Spring inspects annotations by reflection at runtime; with `CLASS` / `SOURCE` retention the pointcut never matches.

```
@Aspect
@Component
@Order(2)               // inner layer: runs after LoggingAspect's @Before
public class TimingAspect {
    private final CallLog log;
    public TimingAspect(CallLog log) { this.log = log; }

    // Matches any bean method annotated with @Timed and binds the annotation to 'timed'
    @Around("@annotation(timed)")
    public Object time(ProceedingJoinPoint pjp, Timed timed) throws Throwable {
        long start = System.nanoTime();
        log.add("timer start [" + timed.value() + "]");
        try {
            return pjp.proceed();          // call the next advice / the real method
        } finally {
            long ms = (System.nanoTime() - start) / 1_000_000;
            log.add("timer stop [" + timed.value() + "] took>=20ms? " + (ms >= 20));
        }
    }
}
```

- `@annotation(timed)` uses the *parameter name*; its type `Timed` tells AspectJ which annotation to look for, and the instance is passed in (`timed.value()`).
- The advice **must return** what `proceed()` returned. An `@Around` method declared `void`, or one that forgets `return`, makes every advised method return `null` — a classic bug.
- Declare `throws Throwable` and let exceptions pass unless you intend to handle them.

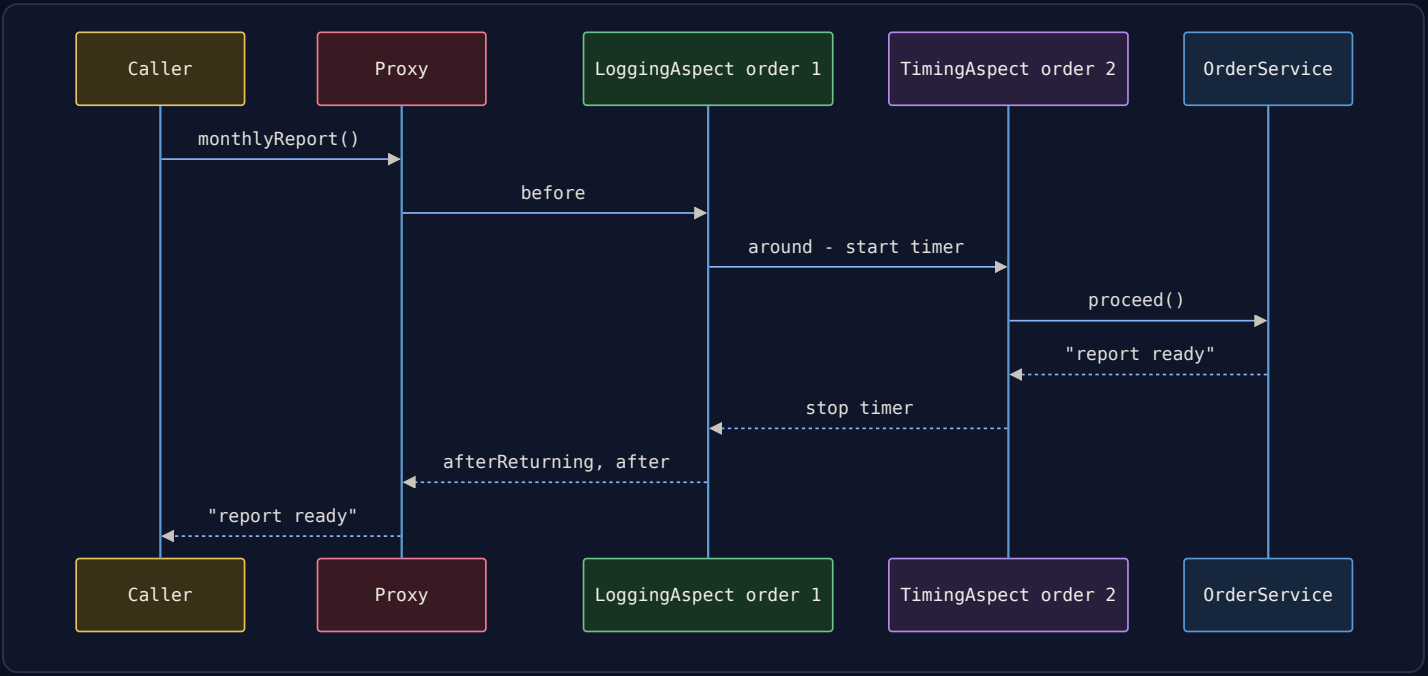
Ordering several aspects

Spring orders aspects on the same method with `@Order` (or `Ordered`). Lower value = higher precedence = **outer** layer: first in, last out. Without an explicit order the sequence is undefined.

```java
@Test
void twoAspectsNestByOrder() throws Exception {
    orders.monthlyReport();
    log.lines().forEach(l -> System.out.println("  " + l));
    assertThat(log.lines()).containsExactly(
            "before monthlyReport args=[]",        // @Order(1) LoggingAspect: outer
            "timer start [monthly-report]",        // @Order(2) TimingAspect: inner
            "timer stop [monthly-report] took>=20ms? true",
            "afterReturning monthlyReport -> report ready",
            "after monthlyReport");
}
```

Output:

```
before monthlyReport args=[]
timer start [monthly-report]
timer stop [monthly-report] took>=20ms? true
afterReturning monthlyReport -> report ready
after monthlyReport
```



Spring's infrastructure advisors (transactions, caching, security) have orders too; a retry aspect must be *outside* the transaction aspect so each retry gets a fresh transaction.

Common mistakes

- **Forgetting** `@Component` on the aspect → nothing happens, no error.
- `@Around` **without** `return pjp.proceed()` → methods return `null`, or the real method never runs.
- **Swallowing exceptions** in `@Around` → callers think a failure succeeded, and an outer `@Transactional` doesn't roll back.
- **Pointcut too broad** (`execution(* *(..))`) → Spring tries to proxy every bean, including infrastructure; startup slows or fails oddly. Restrict to your packages.
- **Relying on unordered aspects** → inconsistent behaviour between runs or environments.

4.3 Pointcut expressions

What it is

A pointcut expression is a tiny query language (from AspectJ) that selects methods. Spring AOP supports a subset of AspectJ's **pointcut designators** (PCDs):

Designator	Matches method executions ...	Example
`execution(...)`	whose signature matches a pattern (the main one)	`execution(* com.shop.service.*.*(..))`
`within(type-pattern)`	declared in matching types/packages	`within(com.shop..*)`
`this(Type)`	where the **proxy** is an instance of `Type`	`this(com.shop.Auditable)`
`target(Type)`	where the **target** is an instance of `Type`	`target(com.shop.Repository)`
`args(...)`	whose runtime arguments match (and binds them)	`args(id, ..)`
`@annotation(A)`	on methods annotated with `A`	`@annotation(com.shop.Timed)`
`@within(A)`	in classes annotated with `A`	`@within(org.springframework.stereotype.Service)`
`@target(A)`	where the target's runtime class has `A`	`@target(com.shop.Audited)`
`@args(A)`	whose argument types carry annotation `A`	`@args(com.shop.Sensitive)`
`bean(name)`	on beans with a matching name — **Spring-only**, not AspectJ	`bean(*Service)`

The `execution` pattern, piece by piece

```
execution( modifiers?  return-type  declaring-type?.method-name(params)  throws? )
execution( public      *            com.shop.service..*Service.find*(Long, ..) )
```

Part	Meaning in the example
`public`	optional; only public methods (with CGLIB proxies, protected/package-private methods can also be matched)
`*`	any return type
`com.shop.service..`	the package `com.shop.service` **or any sub-package** (`..` in a type pattern)
`*Service`	any type whose name ends in `Service`
`find*`	method names starting with `find`
`(Long, ..)`	first parameter `Long`, then zero or more of anything (`..` in a parameter list). `()` = no params, `(*)` = exactly one param of any type

Combining and reusing

Pointcuts combine with `&&`, `||`, `!` and can reference named pointcuts from other classes:

```
public class CommonPointcuts {
    @Pointcut("within(com.shop..web..*)")     public void webLayer() {}
    @Pointcut("within(com.shop..service..*)") public void serviceLayer() {}
    @Pointcut("execution(* com.shop..*Repository.*(..))") public void dataAccess() {}
}

@Before("com.shop.aop.CommonPointcuts.serviceLayer() && args(id, ..)")
public void checkId(Long id) { /* id is bound from the first argument */ }
```

The chapter's `TracingAspect` uses a `within` pointcut that excludes the aspect's own class:

```
@Before("within(ch04.proxy..*) && !within(ch04.proxy.TracingAspect)")
public void trace(JoinPoint jp) { log.add("trace " + jp.getSignature().toShortString()); }
```

Performance tip

Matching is done once per bean method at startup and cached, so runtime cost is small — but **kinded** (`execution`) and **scoping** (`within`) designators are cheapest; contextual ones (`this` , `target` , `args` , `@annotation`) are more expensive alone. Include a `within(...)` scope whenever possible.

Common mistakes

- `com.shop.*` matches only types directly in `com.shop` (one package level — `execution(* com.acme.*.*(..))` misses `com.acme.billing.InvoiceService`); use `com.shop..*` for sub-packages.
- `execution(* save(*))` matches exactly one parameter, not "any parameters" — that is `(..)` .
- A custom trigger annotation only on an **interface** method: `@annotation(...)` matches the method actually executed on the bean class, so annotate the implementation. (Spring's own annotations such as `@Transactional` use a more forgiving lookup.)

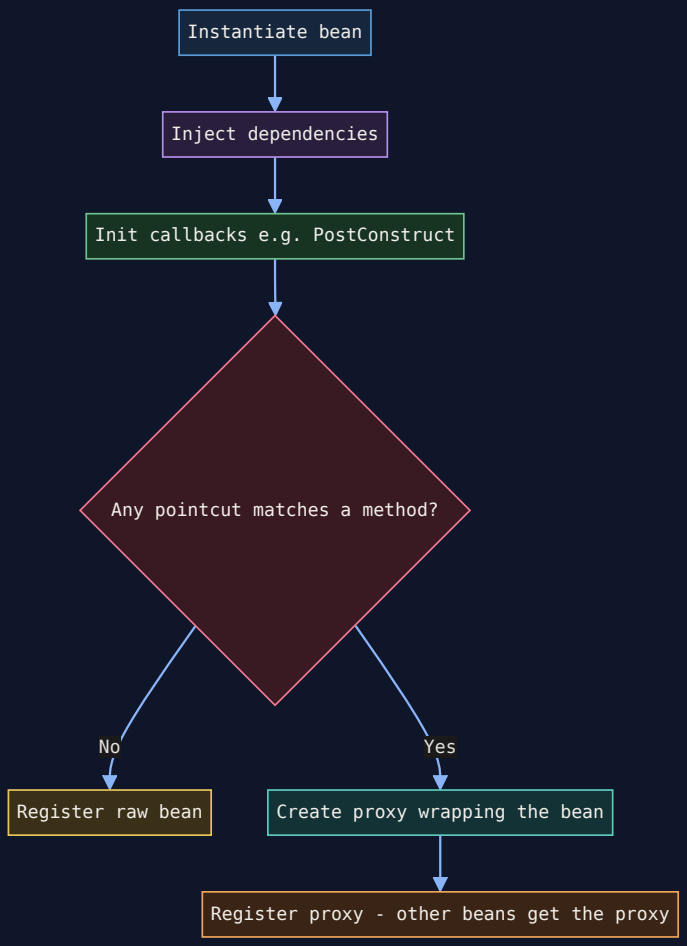
4.4 How Spring AOP works: proxies

What it is

A **proxy** has the same type as your bean (callers can't tell the difference) but forwards each call through the advice chain to the real object. Spring creates proxies **at startup** in a `BeanPostProcessor` (§2.8); for `@Aspect` support that is `AnnotationAwareAspectJAutoProxyCreator` .

How it works

1. The container creates the real bean (constructor, injection, `@PostConstruct`).
2. In `postProcessAfterInitialization` the auto-proxy creator asks: *does any advisor's pointcut match any method of this bean's class?*
3. No: the raw bean is registered. Yes: it builds a proxy with the matching advisors, and **the proxy** is registered and injected everywhere.
4. At call time the proxy walks a chain of interceptors (advice objects that act before and after passing the call on); the last link calls the real method.



Two kinds of proxy

	JDK dynamic proxy	CGLIB proxy
Built with	`java.lang.reflect.Proxy` (part of the JDK)	bytecode generation of a **subclass** (Spring ships a repackaged CGLIB)
Requires	the bean implements at least one interface	the class is not `final` and has a usable constructor
The proxy *is a*	implementation of the interfaces only	subclass of the bean's class
Can be injected as the concrete class?	**No** — `BeanNotOfRequiredTypeException`	Yes
Methods it can intercept	interface methods (public)	non-final, non-private methods (public, protected, package-private within the same package)
Class name you'll see	`jdk.proxy2.$Proxy83`	`OrderService$$SpringCGLIB$$0`

Which one does Spring pick?

- **Plain Spring Framework:** JDK proxy if the bean implements an interface, otherwise CGLIB (unless `proxyTargetClass = true`).
- **Spring Boot:** `spring.aop.proxy-target-class` defaults to `true`, so Boot uses **CGLIB for everything**, even beans with interfaces — so injecting by concrete class never fails. Set it to `false` for plain-Spring behaviour.
- **Framework 7:** `@Proxyable` on a bean class or `@Bean` method overrides the global default for that bean: `@Proxyable(ProxyType.INTERFACES)`, `@Proxyable(ProxyType.TARGET_CLASS)`, or `@Proxyable(interfaces = ...)`

to expose only some interfaces. Framework 7 also merges the proxy settings of the various `@Enable...` annotations into one global default.

Proved in `ProxyTypesTest.java`:

```
static String describe(Object bean) {
    String kind = AopUtils.isJdkDynamicProxy(bean) ? "JDK dynamic proxy"
                : AopUtils.isCglibProxy(bean) ? "CGLIB proxy" : "not a proxy";
    return kind + " -> " + bean.getClass().getName();
}

@Test
void whatKindOfProxyDidSpringCreate() {
    System.out.println("OrderService (no interface):       " + describe(orders));
    System.out.println("DefaultGreetingService (interface): " + describe(greeting));
    System.out.println("@Proxyable(INTERFACES) bean:        " + describe(interfaceOnly));
    assertThat(AopUtils.isCglibProxy(orders)).isTrue();
    assertThat(AopUtils.isCglibProxy(greeting)).isTrue();     // Boot default: proxy-target-class=true
    assertThat(AopUtils.isJdkDynamicProxy(interfaceOnly)).isTrue();
    assertThat(interfaceOnly).isNotInstanceOf(DefaultGreetingService.class);
}
```

where the third bean is:

```
@Service
@Proxyable(ProxyType.INTERFACES)       // ask for a JDK dynamic proxy
public class InterfaceOnlyGreetingService implements GreetingService { ... }
```

Output:

```
OrderService (no interface):       CGLIB proxy -> ch04.aop.OrderService$$SpringCGLIB$$0
DefaultGreetingService (interface): CGLIB proxy -> ch04.proxy.DefaultGreetingService$$SpringCGLIB$$0
@Proxyable(INTERFACES) bean:        JDK dynamic proxy -> jdk.proxy2.$Proxy83
```

A proxy by hand: `java.lang.reflect.Proxy`

A JDK dynamic proxy without Spring: give the JDK interfaces and an `InvocationHandler`; every call lands in `invoke(proxy, method, args)`:

```
GreetingService target = new DefaultGreetingService();
InvocationHandler handler = (proxy, method, args) -> {
    System.out.println("  [handler] before " + method.getName());
    Object result = method.invoke(target, args);      // delegate to the real object
    System.out.println("  [handler] after  " + method.getName());
    return result;
};
GreetingService proxy = (GreetingService) Proxy.newProxyInstance(
        GreetingService.class.getClassLoader(), new Class<?>[] {GreetingService.class}, handler);
String out = proxy.greet("Ada");
System.out.println("result = " + out + ", proxy class = " + proxy.getClass().getSimpleName());
```

```
  [handler] before greet
  [handler] after  greet
result = Hello, Ada, proxy class = $Proxy137
```

Spring's JDK proxies are exactly this, with an `InvocationHandler` that runs the advisor chain.

Spring's `ProxyFactory`

Spring exposes its proxy machinery as `ProxyFactory` (handy in tests or libraries). The advice is an AOP Alliance (a shared set of AOP interfaces) `MethodInterceptor` — the low-level interface all Spring advice is converted into:

```
MethodInterceptor upper = inv -> ((String) inv.proceed()).toUpperCase();

ProxyFactory jdk = new ProxyFactory(new DefaultGreetingService());
jdk.addInterface(GreetingService.class);   // interfaces known + proxyTargetClass=false -> JDK
jdk.addAdvice(upper);
GreetingService p1 = (GreetingService) jdk.getProxy();

ProxyFactory cglib = new ProxyFactory(new DefaultGreetingService());
cglib.setProxyTargetClass(true);           // force a subclass
cglib.addAdvice(upper);
DefaultGreetingService p2 = (DefaultGreetingService) cglib.getProxy();
```

```
factory 1: JDK dynamic proxy -> jdk.proxy2.$Proxy83 says HELLO, BOB
factory 2: CGLIB proxy -> ch04.proxy.DefaultGreetingService$$SpringCGLIB$$1 says HELLO, BOB
```

(The JDK reuses one proxy class per interface set, hence `$Proxy83` twice. The numbers depend on how many proxy classes were generated before, so your run may differ.)

Trade-offs

Concern	JDK proxy	CGLIB proxy
Inject by concrete class	fails	works
`final` classes / methods	irrelevant (interface-based)	class cannot be proxied / method silently not advised
Startup cost	tiny	generates a class per bean (small, cached)
Constructor	not involved	Spring uses Objenesis (creates objects without calling a constructor), so the target's constructor is **not** run again for the proxy
Recommended	when you program to interfaces and want only interface methods exposed	Boot's default; works for classes without interfaces

E.g. in a Boot app a `@Transactional` `PaymentService implements Payments` gets a CGLIB proxy; in plain Spring it gets a JDK proxy, and injecting `PaymentServiceImpl` fails because the proxy only implements `Payments`.

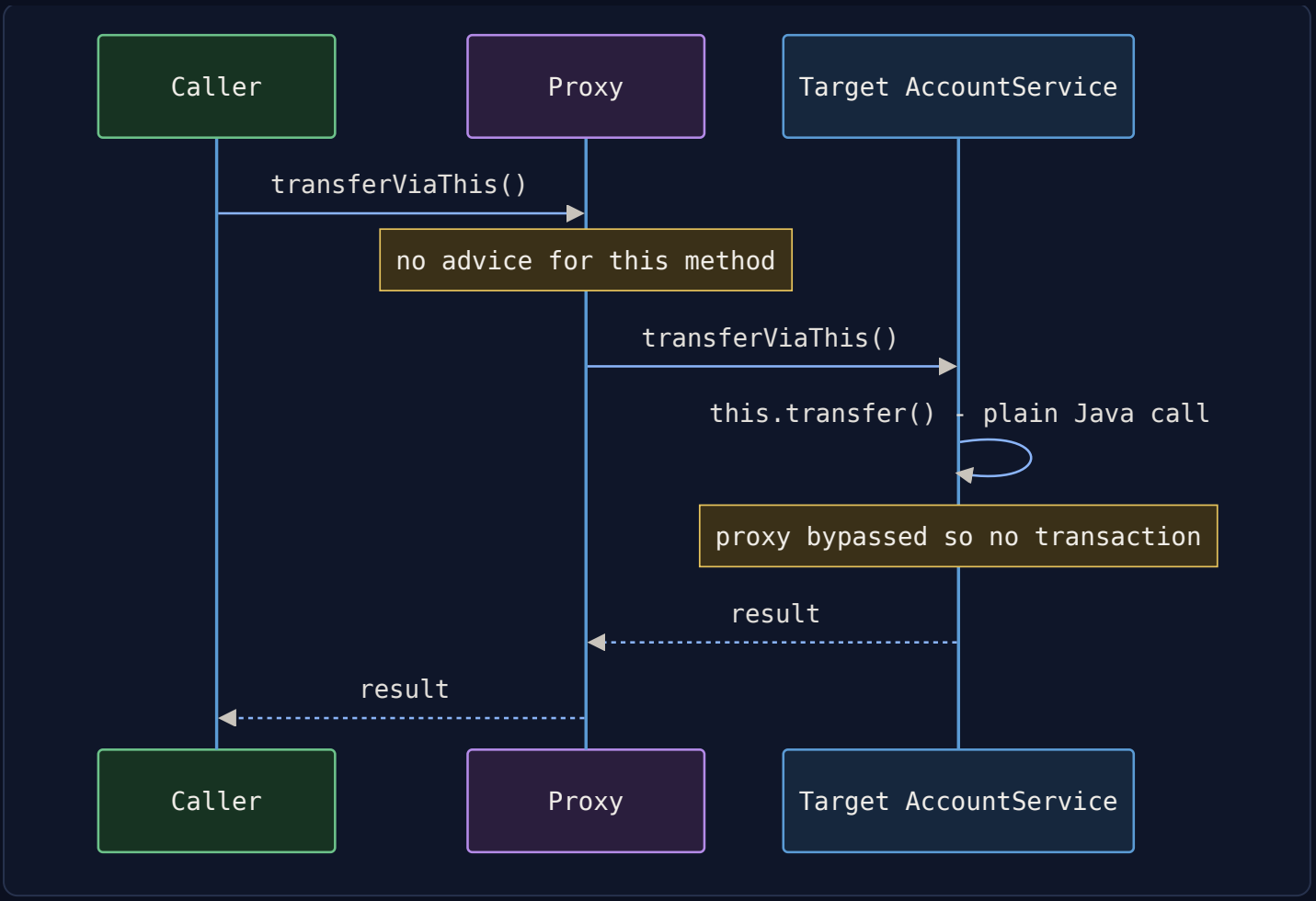
4.5 Proxy limitations — proved

Because the advice lives in the proxy, **advice runs only when a call passes through the proxy**. Every limitation below follows from that.

Self-invocation

What it is

Inside a bean, `this` is the **target object**, not the proxy. `this.someMethod()` (or just `someMethod()`) is a plain Java call that never touches the proxy: no transaction, caching, async, retry or security check.



Proof 1 — `@Transactional`

```
@Service
public class AccountService {
    private final ObjectProvider<AccountService> self;   // lazy handle to *our own proxy*

    public AccountService(ObjectProvider<AccountService> self) { this.self = self; }

    @Transactional
    public String transfer() {
        // true only if a transaction proxy started a transaction before we got here
        return "transaction active = " + TransactionSynchronizationManager.isActualTransactionActive();
    }
    public String transferViaThis()      { return this.transfer(); }             // skips the proxy
    public String transferViaSelfProxy() { return self.getObject().transfer(); }  // goes through it
}
```

`TransactionSynchronizationManager.isActualTransactionActive()` reports whether a real transaction is bound to the current thread (Spring tracks transactions per thread). The project has H2 (in-memory database) + `spring-boot-starter-jdbc`, so Boot configured a `DataSourceTransactionManager`.

Proof 2 — `@Cacheable`

```
@Cacheable("prices")                    // proxy checks the "prices" cache before calling us
public int price(String sku) {
    realCalls.incrementAndGet();         // counts how often the real method body runs
    return sku.length() * 100;
}
public int priceTwiceViaThis(String sku) {
    return this.price(sku) + this.price(sku);   // self-invocation: cache never consulted
}
```

Proof 3 — `@Async`

```
@Async                                  // proxy hands the call to a TaskExecutor thread
public CompletableFuture<String> build() {
    return CompletableFuture.completedFuture(Thread.currentThread().getName());
}
public CompletableFuture<String> buildViaThis() {
    return this.build();                // runs on the CALLER's thread
}
```

The test (SelfInvocationTest.java) asserts all three:

```
caller -> proxy -> transfer():        transaction active = true
caller -> proxy -> this.transfer():   transaction active = false
caller -> proxy -> self.transfer():   transaction active = true
2 external calls -> real method ran 1 time(s)
2 internal calls -> real method ran 2 time(s)
caller thread:          main
@Async through proxy:   task-1
@Async via this.build(): main
```

`task-1` is a thread of Boot's auto-configured `applicationTaskExecutor` (a thread pool of reusable workers). Via `this`, the "async" method ran synchronously on `main` — no error, no warning.

Fixes, best first

1. **Move the method to another bean.** If `transfer()` must be transactional on its own, it probably belongs in a separate service anyway.
2. **Call through the proxy by self-injection** — `ObjectProvider<T>` or `@Autowired @Lazy MyService self` (shown above). Works but surprises readers; comment it.
3. **`AopContext.currentProxy()`** — needs `@EnableAspectJAutoProxy(exposeProxy = true)` and couples code to Spring AOP; the docs discourage it.
4. **Annotate the outer (entry-point) method** instead, if that's what you meant.
5. **AspectJ weaving** (§4.8) — advice woven into bytecode, so `this` calls are advised. Rarely worth the build complexity.

`final` methods on CGLIB proxies

A CGLIB proxy is a subclass, which **cannot override a `final` method** — so a `final` method runs **on the proxy object itself**. Worse, Spring creates proxy instances without running your constructor, so the proxy's fields are `null`.

```
@Service
public class PricingService {
    private final List<String> currencies;
    public PricingService() { this.currencies = List.of("EUR", "USD"); }

    public String currencies()             { return "currencies=" + currencies; }
    public final String currenciesFinal()  { return "currencies=" + currencies; }
}
```

`TracingAspect` advises every method of this class, so it is proxied:

```
String normal = pricing.currencies();
String viaFinal = pricing.currenciesFinal();
System.out.println("normal method: " + normal);
System.out.println("final method:  " + viaFinal);
System.out.println("advice log:    " + log.lines());
assertThat(viaFinal).isEqualTo("currencies=null");           // proxy's own, never-initialised field
```

```
normal method: currencies=[EUR, USD]
final method:  currencies=null
advice log:    [trace PricingService.currencies()]
```

The final method was not advised **and** read `null`. In real code: a mysterious `NullPointerException` on a field that "definitely was injected". Kotlin classes are `final` by default, which is why Kotlin Spring projects use the `kotlin-spring` (all-open) compiler plugin to make annotated classes non-final.

A `final` **class** cannot be subclassed at all; if it needs advice and has no interface, startup fails saying CGLIB cannot subclass it.

Other things proxies cannot advise

Case	Why	What happens
`private` methods	not visible to a subclass, not on an interface	advice silently ignored
`static` methods	not called on an instance	ignored
Calls inside the **constructor** or `@PostConstruct`	proxy does not exist yet / you are on the target	ignored (e.g. no transaction, no async for `@Transactional` / `@Async` called from `@PostConstruct`)
Objects created with `new`	not Spring beans, never proxied	ignored
Field access	Spring AOP supports only method execution join points	not possible (needs AspectJ)
Methods only on the class, with a JDK proxy	the proxy implements only interfaces	not reachable through the proxy

For `@Transactional`: since Framework 6.0, `protected` and package-private methods can be transactional with CGLIB proxies; with interface-based proxies they must be `public`, and `private` never works.

In the interview

30-second answer: "Spring AOP is proxy-based. At startup a BeanPostProcessor wraps any bean matching a pointcut in a proxy — CGLIB by default in Boot, JDK dynamic proxy for interface-only proxying — and other beans get the proxy. Advice runs only when a call goes through the proxy, so `this.method()` calls, private or final methods, and calls from constructors skip `@Transactional`, `@Cacheable`, `@Async` and custom aspects. The fix is usually to move the method to another bean, or call through an injected reference to the proxy."

- *"My `@Transactional` method doesn't roll back — why?"* → Self-invocation; private/final method; the exception is checked (declared with `throws`, e.g. `IOException` — rollback defaults to unchecked `RuntimeException`s only, see Chapter 7); exception caught inside the method; bean created with `new`.
- *"How can you see if a bean is proxied?"* → `AopUtils.isAopProxy(bean)` / `isCglibProxy` / `isJdkDynamicProxy`, or print `bean.getClass()` and look for `$$SpringCGLIB$$` or `$Proxy`.

4.6 Spring features built on proxies

Many annotations in this book are "AOP you did not write". They use infrastructure advisors, not `@Aspect` classes, but obey **all** the rules of §4.5 (e.g. `@PreAuthorize` does not protect a `private` method).

Annotation	Switched on by	Interceptor / processor	Chapter
`@Transactional`	Boot auto-config (`@EnableTransactionManagement` in plain Spring)	`TransactionInterceptor`	7
`@Cacheable`, `@CachePut`, `@CacheEvict`	`@EnableCaching`	`CacheInterceptor`	9
`@Async`	`@EnableAsync`	`AsyncExecutionInterceptor`	14
`@Retryable`, `@ConcurrencyLimit` (Framework 7)	`@EnableResilientMethods`	`RetryAnnotationBeanPostProcessor`, `ConcurrencyLimitBeanPostProcessor`	4.7 below
`@PreAuthorize`, `@PostAuthorize`, `@Secured`	`@EnableMethodSecurity`	`AuthorizationManagerBeforeMethodInterceptor`, ...	10
`@Validated` on a class + constraint annotations on method parameters	Boot auto-config (`MethodValidationPostProcessor`)	`MethodValidationInterceptor`	5
`@Observed` (Micrometer, Spring's metrics library)	an `ObservedAspect` bean	an `@Aspect`	15
Spring Data repository interfaces	`@EnableJpaRepositories` / Boot	JDK proxy generated for the interface	8
`@Configuration` classes (full mode)	always	CGLIB subclass intercepting `@Bean` method calls (not AOP advice, same technique)	2

Order matters when several apply. With `@Retryable` + `@Transactional` on one method, if the transaction interceptor is outside the retry interceptor, all attempts share one transaction already marked rollback-only (doomed to be undone) after the first failure. Put retries one layer up, or set orders explicitly (`@EnableTransactionManagement(order = ...)`, `@EnableResilientMethods(order = ...)`).

4.7 Framework 7 core resilience: `@Retryable` and `@ConcurrencyLimit`

What it is

Spring Framework **7.0** (November 2025) added a small resilience toolkit (keeping an app working when its dependencies fail) to the core, in `org.springframework.resilience.annotation` and `org.springframework.core.retry`:

- **`@Retryable`** — call a method again when it throws, with back-off delay.
- **`@ConcurrencyLimit`** — at most N threads inside a method at a time (a *bulkhead*: a limit that stops one overloaded part from sinking the whole app, named after a ship's watertight walls).
- **`RetryTemplate`** / **`RetryPolicy`** — the same retry logic, programmatically.

They replace most uses of the separate **Spring Retry** project; Boot 4 removed dependency management for Spring Retry. They are **not** a full resilience library: no circuit breaker (stops calling a failing service for a while), rate limiter (caps calls per second) or time limiter (gives up after a deadline) — use Resilience4j or Spring Cloud Circuit Breaker (Chapter 16, circuit breaker notes).

Why it matters

Remote calls fail *transiently*: a timeout, a 503 ("service unavailable") during a deploy, a dropped connection. Retrying once or twice with a short, growing delay turns many such failures into successes. And with **virtual threads** (very cheap JVM-managed threads — Java book 15.4) there is no thread-pool size naturally capping how many callers hit a slow downstream service — `@ConcurrencyLimit` puts that cap back.

How to switch it on

Add `@EnableResilientMethods` to a configuration class. As of Boot 4.1 there is no auto-configuration for it, so without it `@Retryable` is silently ignored.

```
@SpringBootApplication
@EnableCaching          // turns on the @Cacheable proxy
@EnableAsync            // turns on the @Async proxy
@EnableResilientMethods // Framework 7: turns on @Retryable and @ConcurrencyLimit
public class AopApplication { ... }
```

(Alternatively register `RetryAnnotationBeanPostProcessor` and/or `ConcurrencyLimitBeanPostProcessor` beans.)

`@Retryable` attributes (Framework 7.0)

Attribute	Default	Meaning
`includes` / `value`	empty = all exceptions	exception types to retry (also matches **nested causes**)
`excludes`	empty	exception types never to retry
`predicate`	none	a `MethodRetryPredicate` class for custom decisions, applied after includes/excludes
`maxRetries`	`3`	retries **after** the first call → total attempts = 1 + `maxRetries`
`delay`	`1000` ms	wait before the first retry
`multiplier`	`1.0`	each delay = previous × multiplier (exponential back-off when > 1)
`maxDelay`	`Long.MAX_VALUE`	cap for the growing delay
`jitter`	`0`	random variation per delay, so many clients don't retry in lock-step
`timeout`	`0` = none	total time budget for all attempts including delays (since 7.0.2)
`timeUnit`	`MILLISECONDS`	unit for the numeric delay attributes
`...String` variants	—	`maxRetriesString`, `delayString`, ... accept `${...}` placeholders and SpEL

It also works on methods returning `Mono` / `Flux` (Project Reactor's types for 0–1 and 0–N future values; the retry is applied to the reactive pipeline), and publishes a `MethodRetryEvent` per failed attempt, observable with `@EventListener`.

Example: a flaky client

```
@Service
public class InventoryClient {
    // up to 3 retries (4 attempts in total), waiting 10 ms, then 20 ms, then 40 ms
    @Retryable(includes = TransientException.class, maxRetries = 3, delay = 10, multiplier = 2)
    public int stockFor(String sku) {
        attempts.add("attempt " + (attempts.size() + 1));
        if (failuresLeft-- > 0) {
            throw new TransientException("inventory timed out");
        }
        return 42;
    }

    // IllegalArgumentException is not in 'includes', so it is never retried
    @Retryable(includes = TransientException.class, maxRetries = 3, delay = 10)
    public int stockForBadSku(String sku) {
        attempts.add("attempt " + (attempts.size() + 1));
        throw new IllegalArgumentException("bad sku " + sku);
    }
}
```

The tests (ResilienceTest.java) make it fail twice (recovers), ten times (gives up), and with a non-retryable exception:

```
inventory.failNextCalls(2);
int stock = inventory.stockFor("SKU-1");            // succeeds on attempt 3

inventory.failNextCalls(10);
assertThatThrownBy(() -> inventory.stockFor("SKU-1"))
        .isInstanceOf(TransientException.class);    // the LAST original exception
assertThat(inventory.attempts()).hasSize(4);        // 1 call + 3 retries
```

```
stock = 42 after [attempt 1, attempt 2, attempt 3]
gave up after [attempt 1, attempt 2, attempt 3, attempt 4]
IllegalArgumentException -> [attempt 1]
```

When all attempts fail, the caller gets the **last original exception**, not a wrapper — existing `catch` blocks keep working.

`@ConcurrencyLimit`

```
@ConcurrencyLimit(2)                        // default policy BLOCK: extra callers wait
public void print(String doc) throws InterruptedException {
    int now = inside.incrementAndGet();
    maxInside.accumulateAndGet(now, Math::max);
    Thread.sleep(50);                        // hold the "printer" for a while
    inside.decrementAndGet();
}

@ConcurrencyLimit(limit = 1, policy = ConcurrencyLimit.ThrottlePolicy.REJECT)  // 7.0.3+
public void printUrgent(String doc) throws InterruptedException {
    Thread.sleep(100);
}
```

- `value` / `limit`: maximum concurrent invocations **per bean instance**; `1` makes the method behave like a lock on the bean.
- `limitString`: placeholder/SpEL variant, e.g. `"${printer.max-concurrent}"`.
- `policy` (since 7.0.3): `BLOCK` (default) makes extra callers wait; `REJECT` throws `InvocationRejectedException` (a `RejectedExecutionException` subclass) immediately.

6 virtual threads call `print`; a second caller hits `printUrgent` while the first is inside:

```
6 callers, max inside print() at once = 2
second caller -> InvocationRejectedException
```

Programmatic: `RetryTemplate`

For a retry scope of a few lines, or policies chosen at runtime:

```
RetryPolicy policy = RetryPolicy.builder()
        .maxRetries(4)
        .delay(Duration.ofMillis(5))
        .multiplier(2)
        .includes(TransientException.class)
        .build();
RetryTemplate retry = new RetryTemplate(policy);

String result = retry.execute(() -> {
    if (calls.incrementAndGet() < 3) throw new TransientException("busy");
    return "done on call " + calls.get();
});
```

```
RetryTemplate -> done on call 3
```

`execute(...)` throws a checked `RetryException` on exhaustion holding every failure (`getExceptions()`, `getLastException()`, `getRetryCount()`); `invoke(...)` rethrows the last original exception unchecked. A `RetryListener` can observe each attempt (logging, metrics).

Trade-offs: which retry tool?

	Framework 7 `@Retryable` / `RetryTemplate`	Spring Retry (`org.springframework.retry`)	Resilience4j
Where	built into `spring-context` / `spring-core`	separate library, no longer managed by Boot 4	separate library + Spring Boot integration
Retry + back-off + jitter	yes	yes	yes
Recovery method (`@Recover`)	no — catch the exception at the caller	yes	fallback methods
Circuit breaker, rate limiter, time limiter	no	basic circuit breaker only	yes, all
Bulkhead	`@ConcurrencyLimit`	no	semaphore and thread-pool bulkheads
Metrics	via `RetryListener` / `MethodRetryEvent`	listeners	built-in Micrometer metrics
Choose when	simple retries / limits, no extra dependency	legacy code	circuit breaking and rich resilience policies

When not to use it

- **Non-idempotent operations** (charging a card, sending an email) — a retry after a timeout may do the work twice.

  > **Key term — idempotent:** doing it twice has the same effect as doing it once. "Set the price to 10" is idempotent; "add 10 to the balance" is not. An **idempotency key** is a unique id the caller sends so the server can recognise and skip a repeat. See System Design Fundamentals and the Retry pattern notes. Retry only operations safe to repeat, or make them idempotent first.

- **Errors that won't go away** — validation errors, 4xx responses (the *request* was wrong), `NullPointerException`. Set `includes` narrowly.

- **Retry at every layer** — gateway, client library and service each retrying 3 times turns one request into 64 downstream calls ("retry storm"). Retry at one layer.
- **Inside a transaction** — see §4.6.

Common mistakes

- Forgetting `@EnableResilientMethods` → no retries, no error.
- Self-invocation → `this.stockFor()` is not retried.
- Reading `maxRetries = 3` as "3 attempts" → it is 4.
- No jitter across a fleet of instances → synchronised retry waves after an outage.

4.8 Spring AOP vs AspectJ

What it is

AspectJ is the original, full AOP language for Java. Spring borrowed its annotations and pointcut syntax (hence `org.aspectj.lang.annotation.*` imports), but by default does **not** use the AspectJ weaver — it uses its own proxies and only AspectJ's library to *parse and match* pointcuts.

	Spring AOP (default)	AspectJ weaving
How advice is applied	runtime proxy around a bean	bytecode modified at compile time (`ajc`), post-compile, or load time (LTW — load-time weaving — with a Java agent that changes classes as the JVM loads them)
Join points	method execution on Spring beans only	method call and execution, constructor, field get/set, static initialisers, ... on **any** object
Self-invocation, `final` , `private`	not advised	advised
Objects created with `new`	not advised	advised
Setup	add the starter	AspectJ compiler plugin or `-javaagent` , extra build complexity
Performance	a few extra method calls per advised invocation	practically zero overhead (code inlined into the method)
Good for	95% of enterprise needs: transactions, logging, security	fine-grained or domain-object advice, very hot paths

`@Transactional` , `@Cacheable` and `@Async` can switch to AspectJ mode (`@EnableTransactionManagement(mode = AdviceMode.ASPECTJ)` plus the weaver), removing the self-invocation limitation. Few teams do; extracting a bean is simpler.

When not to use AOP at all

- **Business logic** — a domain rule ("orders over 1000 need approval") belongs explicitly in the service; hidden advice is hard to follow and test.
- **When a decorator (a wrapper object adding behaviour), filter or interceptor fits** — HTTP concerns belong in servlet filters / `HandlerInterceptor` (Chapter 5); client concerns in `ClientHttpRequestInterceptor` (Chapter 6).
- **Very broad pointcuts** — "log every method" is noise and cost; use tracing/metrics tools (Chapter 15).

Real-world examples

- **Spring itself**: transactions, caching, security, async, retries.

- **Micrometer** `@Timed` / `@Observed` — aspects recording metrics/traces.
- **Audit logging** in banking/insurance: an `@Audited` annotation + `@AfterReturning` advice writing who-did-what records.
- **Multi-tenant routing** (one app serving many customer organisations with separate data): an `@Around` aspect sets a tenant id in a `ThreadLocal`/scoped value before repository calls and clears it after.
- **Feature flags / rate limits** on specific methods via custom annotations.

4.9 Common mistakes (whole chapter)

Symptom	Likely cause	Fix
Aspect never runs	aspect is not a bean; starter missing; pointcut doesn't match	add `@Component`; add `spring-boot-starter-aspectj`; test the pointcut
`@Transactional` / `@Cacheable` / `@Async` / `@Retryable` ignored	self-invocation; private/final method; bean made with `new`; missing `@Enable...`	extract to another bean; make method public and non-final; inject the bean; enable the feature
`NullPointerException` on an injected field inside a method	`final` method on a CGLIB proxy runs on the proxy	remove `final`
`BeanNotOfRequiredTypeException`	JDK proxy injected where the concrete class is expected	inject the interface, or use CGLIB (Boot default)
Advised method returns `null`	`@Around` advice doesn't return `proceed()`'s result	`return pjp.proceed();`
Slow startup / weird errors after adding an aspect	pointcut matches infrastructure beans	scope with `within(com.yourapp..*)`
Retry happens inside a failing transaction	transaction interceptor wraps the retry interceptor	retry at a higher layer or set advisor orders

---

4.10 In the interview

Q: What is AOP and how does Spring implement it? AOP modularises cross-cutting concerns such as logging, transactions and security. You write an aspect containing advice and a pointcut; Spring applies it at runtime by wrapping matching beans in proxies created by a `BeanPostProcessor`. Callers get the proxy, which runs the advice chain and then the real method.

- *Follow-up: advice types?* → `@Before`, `@AfterReturning`, `@AfterThrowing`, `@After`, `@Around`. Only `@Around` controls whether the method runs and what it returns; `@AfterThrowing` doesn't stop the exception.
- *Follow-up: order two aspects?* → `@Order` / `Ordered`; lower value is the outer layer.
- *Follow-up: join point in Spring AOP?* → Only method execution on a Spring bean.

Q: JDK dynamic proxy vs CGLIB — which does Spring Boot use? CGLIB for all beans by default (`spring.aop.proxy-target-class=true`), which allows injecting by class. Plain Spring uses JDK proxies when interfaces exist. Framework 7 adds `@Proxyable` to override per bean.

- *Follow-up: limits of CGLIB?* → No `final` classes; `final`/`private` methods are not advised; `final` methods even run on the uninitialised proxy instance.

Q: Why might `@Async` / `@Transactional` not work? → Self-invocation (most common), not a Spring bean, private/final method, missing `@EnableAsync`/transaction manager, or for transactions: checked exception

/ exception swallowed. (Details and proofs in §4.5.)

Q: What's new for resilience in Spring Framework 7? → `@Retryable` (delay, multiplier, jitter, maxDelay, includes/excludes, reactive support; attempts = 1 + `maxRetries`, last exception rethrown), `@ConcurrencyLimit` (bulkhead, BLOCK or REJECT), enabled with `@EnableResilientMethods`; plus `RetryTemplate` / `RetryPolicy` in `spring-core`. No circuit breaker — use Resilience4j.

- *Follow-up: danger of retries?* → Duplicate side effects on non-idempotent operations and retry storms; retry only transient errors, add jitter, retry in one layer.

Q: Spring AOP vs AspectJ? → Spring AOP: proxies, method execution on beans only, easy. AspectJ: bytecode weaving, any join point, no self-invocation problem, more build complexity.

4.11 Chapter TL;DR

- **AOP** = write a cross-cutting concern once (an **aspect**: **advice** + **pointcut**) and apply it to many **join points** (in Spring: bean method executions).
- `@Aspect` **+** `@Component`, `spring-boot-starter-aspectj` (Boot 4 name). Five advice types; `@Around` must `return pjp.proceed()`. Order aspects with `@Order` (lower = outer).
- Pointcuts: `execution(...)`, `within(...)`, `@annotation(...)`, `args(...)`, `bean(...)`; `..` means "any sub-package" or "any parameters".
- Spring AOP is **proxy-based**. Boot uses **CGLIB** subclasses by default; JDK proxies implement interfaces only; Framework 7's `@Proxyable` overrides per bean.
- **Advice runs only through the proxy**: self-invocation, `private`, `final`, `static`, constructor/`@PostConstruct` calls and `new` objects are not advised — proved for `@Transactional`, `@Cacheable`, `@Async` and a `final` method.
- `@Transactional`, `@Cacheable`, `@Async`, `@PreAuthorize`, `@Validated`, `@Retryable` are all proxy features with the same rules.
- Framework 7 **resilience**: `@EnableResilientMethods`, `@Retryable` (attempts = 1 + `maxRetries`, last exception rethrown), `@ConcurrencyLimit` (BLOCK/REJECT), `RetryTemplate`. No circuit breaker in core.
- Next: Chapter 5 — Spring MVC and REST.